SENSay for parents and carers

A voice for your child, and a record for you

Guide	SENSay for parents and carers
Date	23 Oct 2026
For	Parents and carers of pre-verbal and non-verbal children
In short	Your child taps words and the board speaks for them. You get each message by email or text, with what SENSay noticed and how you might respond, and over the weeks you see the patterns behind what your child is telling you
Help	support@sensay.uk

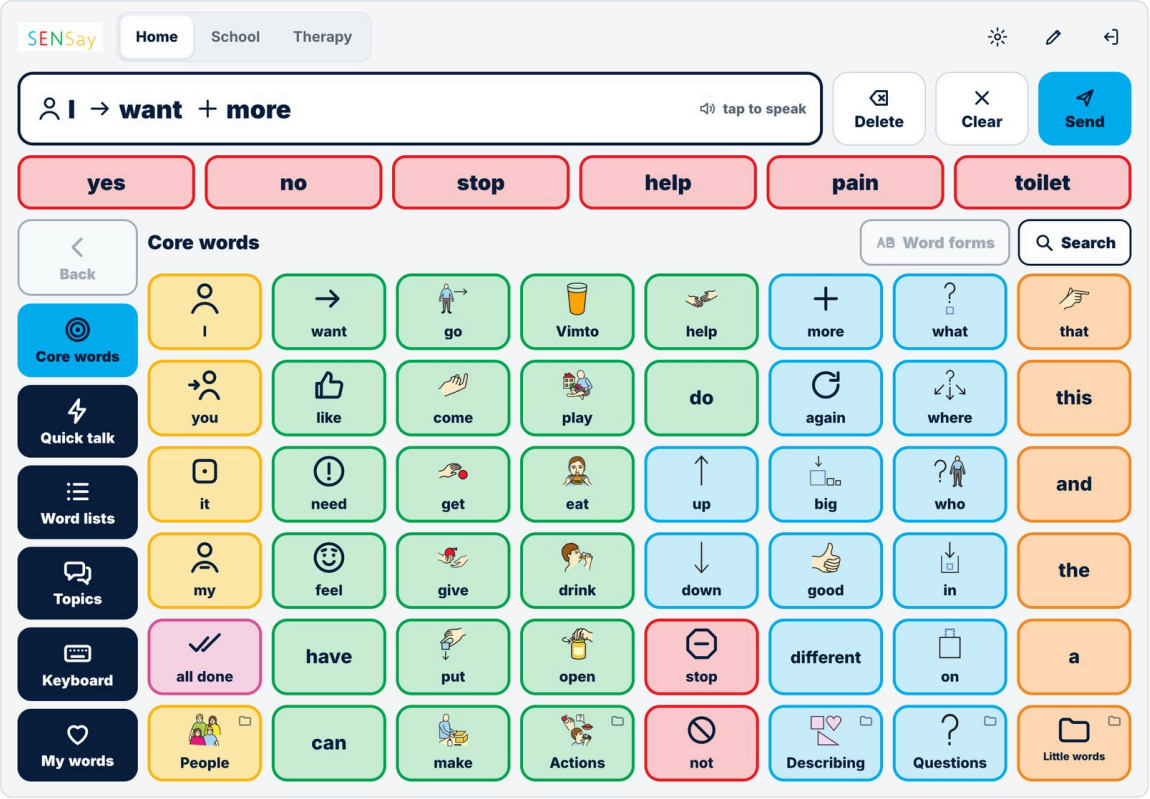
1. What SENSay does for your family

SENSay gives your child a voice and gives you a record of what they tell you. Your child taps words on a board and it speaks for them. You get each message by email or text the moment it is sent, and over the weeks SENSay shows you the patterns: what they ask for, when, where, and what came just before.

We built it for our own son, William. He is ten, autistic and has never spoken, and he tells us things all day long. For years we kept missing them, and by the next school meeting or clinic appointment the moment had gone. SENSay is the tool we wish we had had.

Three promises we make to every family:

- **Your child's voice is never behind a paywall.** The board, the speech and sending a message always work, whatever plan you are on and whether or not the AI is switched on.
- **Your child's words always come first.** Anything SENSay adds is clearly labelled as a suggestion for you, never as something your child said.
- **Your child's data is yours.** It is never sold, never used to train AI, and you can delete it at any time.



The board on a tablet: core words in fixed places, quick words along the top, and the message being built in the bar

2. Getting started

Setting up takes about 15 minutes. You can do it on a phone, tablet or computer at app.sensay.uk.

1. **Create your account.** Sign up with your email and a password, then confirm your email.
2. **Choose "I am a parent".** SENSay asks a few questions about your child: their first name, date of birth, the people in their life, their school and school days, their favourite foods, activities and places, and what helps them feel calm.
3. **Add their documents (optional, but worth it).** Under Child profile, then Documents, upload an EHCP, a therapy report or a letter, as a PDF, Word file, photo or pasted text. SENSay's AI reads it and suggests what to add to the profile. Nothing is saved until you check each item and confirm it.
4. **Add allergies and food rules.** Under Child profile, then Restrictions. These are applied everywhere on the board, so a food your child must not have never appears as a choice.
5. **Open the board.** Press Start communicating.

The profile matters because it shapes the board. The people you add appear on the People pages with the right picture: Nanny Sue appears beside nan and grandad. Favourite foods, drinks, places and activities appear on the matching word lists. You never have to build them by hand.

3. The board

The board is built around **core words**: 43 of the words children use most, such as I, want, more, help, stop, go, like and all done, with five folders for more. They sit in the same place every time, so your child learns where a word is by position, not by reading. Colours show what kind of word each one is: yellow for people, green for actions, blue for describing words, orange for things, pink for social words and red for no and stop.

Section	What is in it
Core words	43 everyday words in fixed places, with folders for more people, actions, describing words, questions and little words
Quick talk	Ready-made phrases and feelings: hello, thank you, I need a break, it hurts, I don't understand
Word lists	32 lists such as food, drinks, animals, body, clothes, places, toys, transport and colours
Topics	36 everyday situations, such as bath time, the park, the dentist, swimming, a birthday party and snack time
Keyboard	Letters with word suggestions that learn from your child's own words
My words	Your family's own pages, photos and videos

Along the top of every page is a strip of six words that never move: **yes, no, stop, help, pain and toilet**. Whatever page your child is on, they can always say the things that matter most.

Building a message

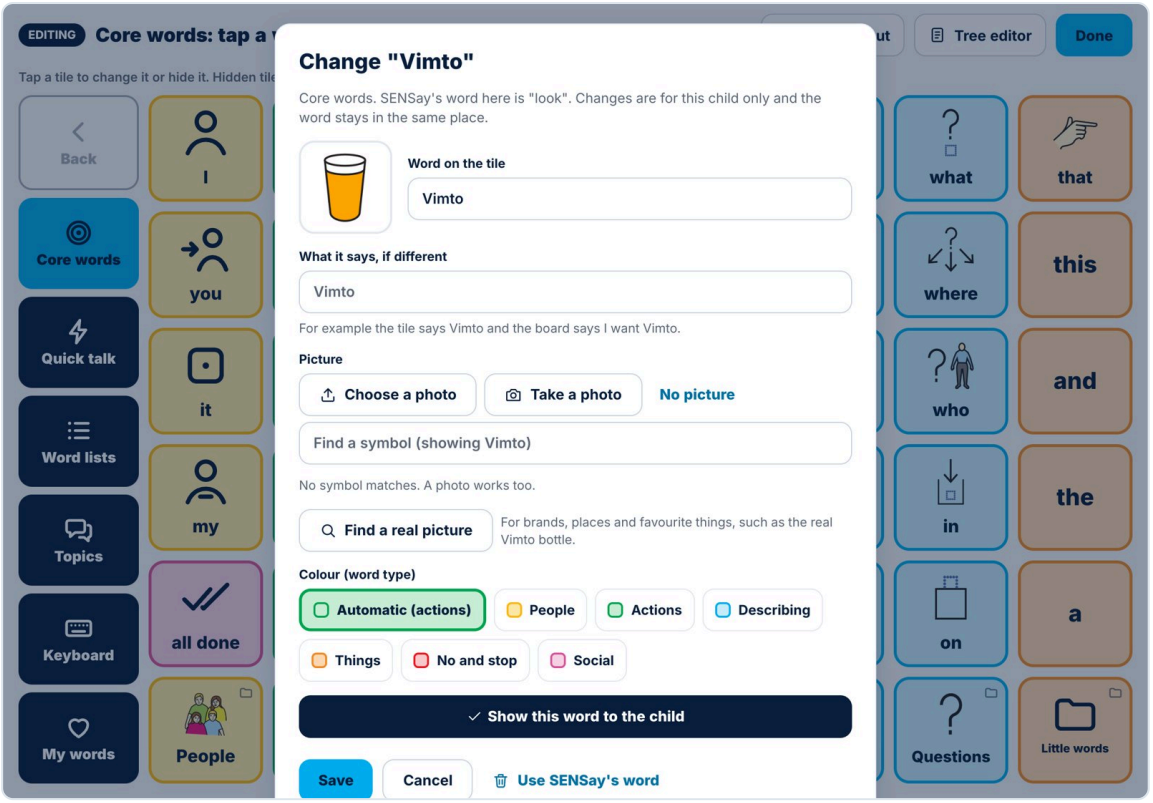
Your child taps words and they appear in the message bar, read aloud one by one. Tapping the bar reads the whole message. **Send** speaks the message and sends it to you. If the internet drops, the message is kept on the device and sent as soon as the connection is back.

Word forms changes the last word: want becomes wants or wanted, dog becomes dogs. **Search** finds where any word lives and opens that page with the word outlined, which helps you learn the board too.

Making it right for your child

Changes are made in edit mode. To keep it away from little fingers, press and hold the edit button for two seconds, then answer a simple sum.

- **Start small.** In Board settings, choose a level. First words shows about 16 core words, Growing about 32, and Full all 43. The other cells stay empty, so when you move up a level new words appear around the ones your child already knows. Nothing ever moves.
- **Change any word.** Tap it in edit mode. Rename it, change what the board says (the tile can say Vimto and the board say "I want Vimto"), choose a different symbol, use your own photo, change its colour, or hide it. Hidden words leave a gap, so nothing else moves.
- **Add words in empty cells.** Tap the plus in any empty cell.
- **Use real pictures.** Press Find a real picture to search free picture libraries, including the real packaging of food and drinks. If you save a word with no picture, SENSay finds one for you when Find real pictures automatically is on.
- **Switch sections on or off.** If Topics or the Keyboard are too much for now, turn them off in Board settings.
- **Choose a voice.** Pick from character voices, including a young girl, a young boy and a little one, and set the speed and pitch. Use Test this voice to hear it.



Changing a word: the tile says Vimto, with SENSay's own word kept underneath

Home, School and Therapy

At the top of the board you choose where your child is: Home, School or Therapy. This decides who receives the messages, so the school staff you add get messages sent at school and your therapy contacts get messages sent in therapy. You get every message, wherever your child is, unless you choose urgent messages only.

4. Messages to your phone

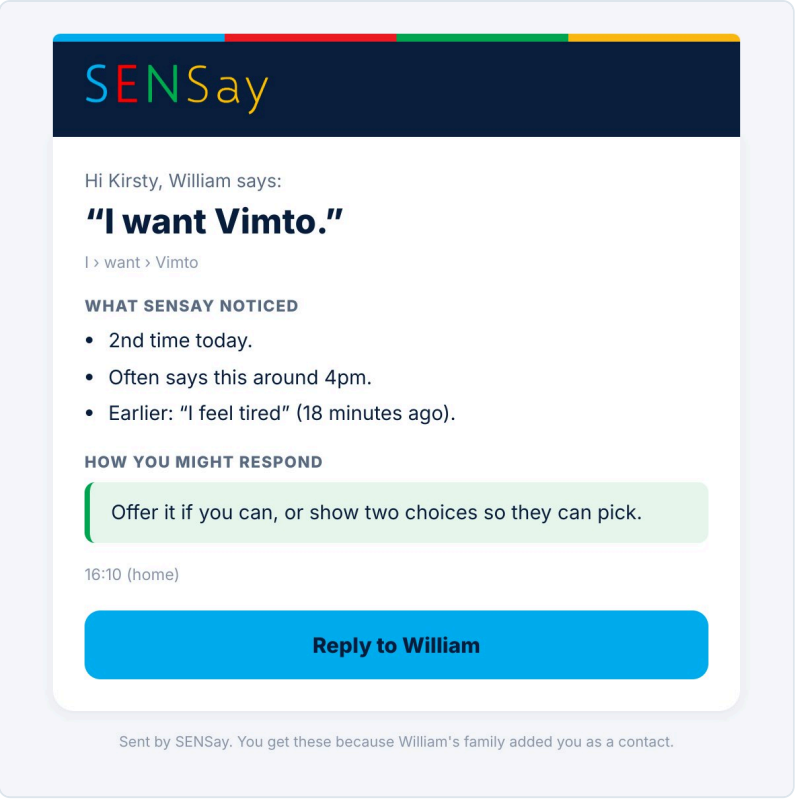
Every message your child sends can reach you by email, by text, or both. It is not just the words. Each one carries a short note:

- **What your child said,** in their own words, first and largest.
- **What SENSay noticed,** such as "2nd time today", "often says this around 4pm", "new word: thirsty" or "Earlier: I feel tired (18 minutes ago)".
- **How you might respond,** one practical suggestion.

Urgent messages always come through. Anything about pain, feeling ill, breathing, needing help, feeling scared, being hurt or touched, the toilet, or wanting something to stop is marked urgent and sent straight away, every time.

Repeats do not flood your phone. Children often enjoy tapping the same thing again and again. The same non-urgent message within 10 minutes is not sent again, and non-urgent messages are limited to 30 an hour. When a message has been tapped several times in a few minutes, the note says it may be play.

Any message with help or stop in it is treated as urgent, so "help me open it" comes through as urgent. We would rather you got one alert too many than missed one.



The email you receive, with what SENSay noticed and a suggested response

Setting it up

Go to Settings, then Notifications.

1. Turn on email or text messages for yourself and add your mobile number.
2. Add other people: a partner, grandparent, teacher or therapist. For each one choose email or text, and whether they get every message or **urgent messages only**.
3. Press **Send a test** to check it arrives.

Replying

Each message has a **Reply** link. Type a short reply, up to 100 characters, such as "I'm coming, two minutes". It is read aloud on your child's board in their chosen voice, so they know you heard them. Reply links work for 7 days.

5. Understanding your child

The parent side of the app turns your child's messages into a picture you can use.

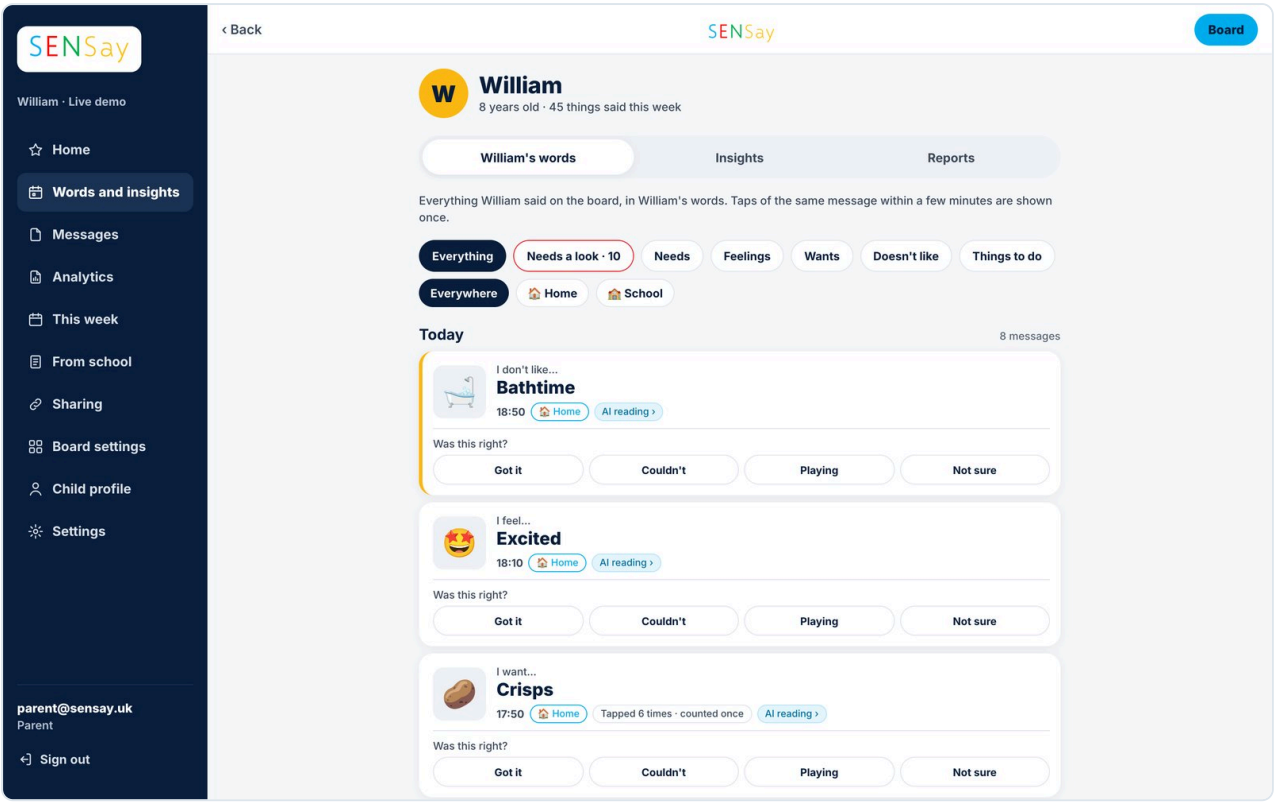
Where	What it shows
Home	Today's and this week's messages, the last message, and an insight of the day
Words and insights	Every message, the patterns, and a weekly report you can download as a PDF or turn into a letter drafted by AI
Messages	The full log, filtered by home, school or therapy, with urgent messages marked
Analytics	Most used messages, time of day, day of the week, routines and bursts of repeated taps
This week	Seven days at a glance, by setting, with a weekly summary

Where	What it shows
From school	Your child's targets and progress, the next review, and notes from therapy

"Was this right?" Under each message you can say whether you understood it: Got it, Couldn't, Playing or Not sure. Marking a message as Playing keeps it out of the counts, so the patterns stay honest.

Repeats are counted once. If your child taps "crisps" twenty times in a minute, the analytics count it once. You see real requests, not a burst of fun.

AI is a suggestion, never a fact. AI insights are on when you start. SENSay may suggest what a message might mean, for example "William may be thirsty after PE". It is always labelled as a suggestion and never shown on your child's board, and you can switch it off, on the board and in emails, in Board settings.



Words and insights: messages, patterns and the weekly report

6. Working with school and therapists

SENSay works best when everyone around your child sees the same picture.

Linking to school

1. Go to Sharing and press **Generate school link code**. You get a code like SEN-4F7K2QX9.
2. Give it to your child's teacher or SENCO. It works once and lasts 24 hours.
3. They enter it under Pupils. From then on, messages sent with the board set to School reach school staff, and their targets and progress appear under **From school**.

Before an annual review, the school may ask for your views. You can write them under From school, and they go into the review pack alongside your child's own views.

Sharing with a therapist

Under Sharing, choose **Share with a therapist** and enter their email. Choose what they can see:

- **Everything:** board messages, targets, school evidence and reviews.
- **Plans and progress only:** everything except board messages.

You can change this or stop sharing at any time, and their access ends straight away. Therapists can add notes after sessions, including advice for home and school, which you see under From school.

7. Your child's data

- **Where it is kept:** on secure servers in the EU (Ireland), encrypted when stored and when sent.
- **Who can see it:** you, and only the school staff and therapists you link or share with.
- **What we never do:** sell it, use it to train AI, or share it with anyone except the services that run SENSay (our AI, email and text providers), under contract.
- **Deleting it:** Settings, then Delete my account removes your account and everything in it.

8. What it costs

- **The board is free for every child,** and always will be.
- **The family plan,** for the parent side (insights, reports, messages to your phone and sharing), is £7.99 a month or £79 a year, including VAT. It opens in 2027.
- **If your child's school has a SENSay licence, the family plan is free.** If you already pay and your child's school then joins, your subscription stops.
- **A family support price of £3.99 a month** is available on request, with no questions asked.
- **Until the family plan opens, everything in this guide is free.**

9. Tips from our family

- **Model, model, model.** Tap the words yourself as you talk: "I want… drink". Children learn a board by seeing adults use it. Only messages that are sent are recorded, so press Clear when you have finished showing. When your child is linked to a school, an Adult modelling switch also appears above the board, so a message you send while modelling is marked as yours, not your child's.
- **Start with a few words that matter.** More, stop, help and a favourite food or toy get a fast reward.
- **Keep the board with your child,** at meals, in the car and at the park, not in a drawer.
- **Respond every time,** even if the answer is "not now". A message that gets a reply is worth sending again.
- **Expect play.** Exploring the board by tapping is part of learning it. SENSay keeps play out of the patterns, so you do not need to stop it.

10. Help

Email support@sensay.uk. We are a family too, and we read every message.